There is a striking symmetry: **GUPTA RE-INTERPRETS THE PRE-RAPHAELITES** in India and Singh reconstructs Company art in Britain



OTHER TALES Sunil Gupta's artwork at the Leamington Spa art gallery; below, the exhibition brochure

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN CONTEMPORARY ARTISTS ENTER a museum collection and begin asking questions of its silences? This is the premise of *Unruly Desires: Reframing the Past*, an exhibition at Leamington Spa Art Gallery & Museum in Warwickshire, England, that brings together the works of Sunil Gupta and Charan Singh. Partners in both life and art, the two photographers engage with the museum's collection to explore queer identity, beauty, desire and visibility, revealing histories overlooked within traditional art historical narratives.

On view until September 6, the exhibition places Gupta's *The New Pre-Raphaelites* series alongside Singh's ongoing *The Promise of Beauty* project and newly commissioned works responding directly to objects in the museum's collection. Although their approaches differ, both artists are interested in how historical images can be reimagined through contemporary queer perspectives.

For Gupta, *The New Pre-Raphaelites* captures a pivotal moment in India's LGBTQ+ history. Created in 2008 during the legal challenge to Section 377 of the then Indian Penal Code, the series reinterpreted Pre-Raphaelite paintings through photographs of friends and activists in Delhi. Looking back, Gupta now sees the works as documents of a generation demanding change. "In the mid-2000s, the atmosphere had radically changed," he recalls. "Talk and discussion spilled out from campuses into the city and young people wanted change now. It was a moment I recognised from the work of the Pre-Raphaelites in England."

The series also reflects Gupta's experience of migration. Born in New Delhi and later moving to Canada and Britain, he has described his work as being shaped by both geographical movement and the journey towards a gay identity. "The collision of my western art and gay liberation training with the young queer activists in Delhi who were emerging from graduate school led to the creation of the photographs in this show," he explains.

That dialogue becomes especially visible in the exhibition itself, where Gupta's photographs are shown alongside works from the museum's collection, including Simeon Solomon's 'Sleepers and One that Waketh'. "There's a hidden queer history here for England and British people themselves," says Gupta. "It means a local audience can see the connection between Britain and India, so it's not just something happening in Delhi but of interest over here too."

Questions of visibility also run